



India's telecom duopoly

How Airtel and Jio came out controlling the market

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India once had over a dozen telecom operators competing for customers.

Airtel sold unlimited calls, Tata Docomo charged by the second, Reliance gave free night calls, and Uninor undercut everyone on data. Users had choices, and operators had to fight for every customer. However, that era has ended. Today, India has four major telecom operators left, which are Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel, Vodafone Idea (Vi), and BSNL. When you exclude the state-owned player and the struggling telecom company, the private market is down to just two names, Airtel and Jio. Everything from your monthly recharge to your data speed is now decided by a contest between these two companies.

Vi and BSNL are still technically in the race, but neither is in a position to start a price war. Vi has been bleeding money and users for years, and BSNL still leans on government support to even stay in business. Not only that, but both companies are also playing a catch-up game on 5G technology, a race Airtel and Jio started years back and are already winning. With their hands full trying to stay relevant in the network game, raising prices is a risk they can't take. That single fact tells you almost everything about why this market behaves like a duopoly even though four names appear on paper.

Recent price hikes

Every few years, users are reminded that the telecom market does not work

in their favour. Whether it be unlimited calling, cheap data benefits, free 5G or added benefits, everything has a cost that they have to bear. And the most recent reminder of the same has been served by Airtel, as the telecom giant quietly discontinued one of its most popular Rs 299 recharge plans recently and has silently pushed the users toward a costlier Rs 349 option.

However, this wasn't the only nail in the coffin, as the telecom giant also took away the Rs 579, Rs 619, and Rs 649 recharge plans from consumers. Moreover, the company has also increased the price of its existing Rs 859 plan to Rs 899.

One thing worth noting about the situation is that Airtel has not made any formal announcement regarding the removal of these plans. If a formal price hike follows this silent removal, and going by Airtel's historical pricing patterns, the new base prepaid plan of Rs 349 may potentially cost around Rs 399, which would be a 33.44 per cent increase when compared with the Rs 299 plan. Do note, the Rs 399 figure is a projection based on past pricing behaviour, not a confirmed number, and should be read as such.

Jio and Vi are no different, as the telecom operators also took a similar step back in 2021 and 2024 when they increased the prices of some of their prepaid plans by up to 25 per cent. Industry publications tracking telecom pricing have also reported that Jio is preparing a fresh round of tariff increases in the range of 12 to 15 per cent within the next few months, following Airtel's revised prepaid lineup, though neither company has confirmed exact figures or a timeline.

Save yourself from price hike

Jio has also launched a Jio Prime Membership for Rs 300 recently that lets users lock in their recharge prices for a year. The company is promoting it as a countermeasure to price hikes, but it's